NDA POLL PROMISES...

- **Mass employment:** Creation of 10 million jobs and employment opportunities over five years
- **Mahila Rojgar Yojana:** Rs 10,000 distributed to 15.1 million women to start micro-enterprises; up to Rs 2 lakh proposed to scale viable ventures
- **Lakhpati Didis:** An aspirational pledge to empower 10 million women to earn Rs 1 lakh annually
- **Infrastructure & industry boost:** Attracting investments worth Rs 50 lakh crore to spur jobs, growth

...AND THE CHALLENGES

- **POLITICAL:** Nitish may have retained CM's seat, but BJP's emergence as the single largest party means it will assert its ideological and political agenda more forcefully. This new coalition dynamics will leave Nitish with narrow manoeuvring space
- **ECONOMIC:** The promise of attracting Rs 50 lakh crore investments faces structural hurdles—limited availability of contiguous land, slow clearances and infrastructural gaps in power, water and logistics
- **BUDGETARY:** The new government will have to find the finances to fund its big-ticket promises. Just giving the additional Rs 2 lakh to 15.1 million Mahila Rojgar Yojana beneficiaries will add up to Rs 3.02 lakh crore. This, when the state's total budget is just Rs 3.17 lakh crore

nounced, overwhelmed by the faith Bihar reposed in his leadership, Nitish had posted on X: "Bihar will progress further and will join the ranks of the most developed states in the country." Optimism of the will aside, that's a daunting piece of commitment.

THE BIG TASKS BEFORE NITISH

For Nitish, Bihar is at once recognisably transformed yet stubbornly familiar. The state's economy has more than tripled since 2011; its gross state domestic product grew by 9.2 per cent in 2023–24. Electricity now reaches every household, and roads connect every village. Yet, beneath this shining narrative runs a strain of continuity that has long confounded reformers. Bihar may have halved multidimensional poverty (that maps deprivations in health, education and standard of living) from 51.9 per cent in 2015-16 to 26.59 per cent in 2022-23, but it is still among the states with the highest multidimensional poverty. At Rs 69,300, per capita income remains barely a third of the national average; the Bihar Caste Survey 2023 found that over 9.4 million families—around 34 per cent of the state's population—survive on meagre incomes, with roughly the same proportion earning Rs 6,000 or less per month.

Cast across time, Bihar's per capita net state domestic product at current prices rose from Rs 3,372 in 1994–95 to Rs 69,321 in 2024–25—an extraordinary absolute leap in just three decades—but the figure remains stubbornly low at a little over 33 per cent of the national average, a proportion that has barely shifted in nearly 35 years. That lingering gap, more than any single statistic, suggests that Bihar's development stays suppressed by a glass ceiling. Breaking that will require Nitish to drive value-added growth: moving industry and services into higher-productivity sectors, nurturing local entrepreneurship and creating incentives that persuade private capital to stay invested in Bihar across multiple political cycles. But before that, Nitish has election pledges to honour.

PROMISES TO KEEP

People close to Nitish say he has been visibly moved by the depth of trust the electorate has reposed in him and views it as a moral obligation to fulfil the promises he has made. Among these pledges is the Mukhya Mantri Mahila Rojgar Yojana, offering support of up to Rs 2.10 lakh for every eligible aspiring woman entrepreneur. As a pre-election demonstration of intent, the government transferred Rs 10,000 in seed money to 15.1 million women—an administrative feat unparalleled in Bihar's history, and one that instantly altered the political momentum. The impact was unmistakable. The beneficiaries make up over 42 per cent of Bihar's 35 million registered female voters. Observers believe it was the single reason that women voters outnumbered men in turnout on such a scale: 71.77 per cent of them casting their vote, the highest since 1951, compared to 62.72 per cent men.

If Nitish gives the remaining ₹2 lakh to the 15.1 mn Mahila Rojgar Yojana beneficiaries who got the first tranche of ₹10,000, it'll cost the state ₹3.02 lakh crore—95% of its ₹3.17 lakh crore budget

And now that they have rewarded him with a tenth term, Nitish has to find the finances to fulfil his side of the bargain. The seed money for the Mahila Rojgar Yojana